adrian zhang

# war

for piano quartet

(2023)

Mvt. I: Conflict
Movement one of my piece symbolizes the violence of warfare. Although primarily chaotic and dissonant, the melody emerges from a systematic structural foundation: the repetition of similar or identical motives functions much like the perpetual attacking and defending of key strongholds. In such areas, listeners may discover the deliberate placement of what I would call "inverse chords," chords with the same complexity, but opposite feelings (augmented and diminished, for example), which relates to the strategic positioning and movement of troops in battle.

Mvt. II: Desolation
Movement two introduces the audience to the direct aftermath of the war. Following the ceasefire, the survivors naturally sigh with relief, but they soon must confront the harsh realities: their comrades are dead, and what may have become routine—gunshots, explosions, and the like—has been replaced by dead silence, punctuated by occasional bouts of shellshock. The second movement mirrors this experience, with slow chords interrupted by fragments of sound: the relief mingled with the haunting memories of the past. Yet, to reflect the survivors' attempts to cope, the second movement interjects a more hopeful interlude. However, the question remains: will they really be able to move on? This movement is longer than the first to signify how the effects of the survivors' trauma outlast any battle.

Mvt. III: Death
Movement three of my piece finds inspiration in the kiss of death present in Heinz Weinbeck's "Now and in the hour of death." Like a bell, the tritone of the piano rings forth to announce the movement's beginning, abruptly transitioning to an ear-piercing strings motif, before flowing eerily back to the piano again. The strings' chord increases in complexity, but remains creepily dissonant, reflecting the ever-growing number of funerals for the soldiers lost in battle while the ghastly messenger continues adding to the death toll. This is the longest movement, as the mourning of the dead will linger on for at least a generation.

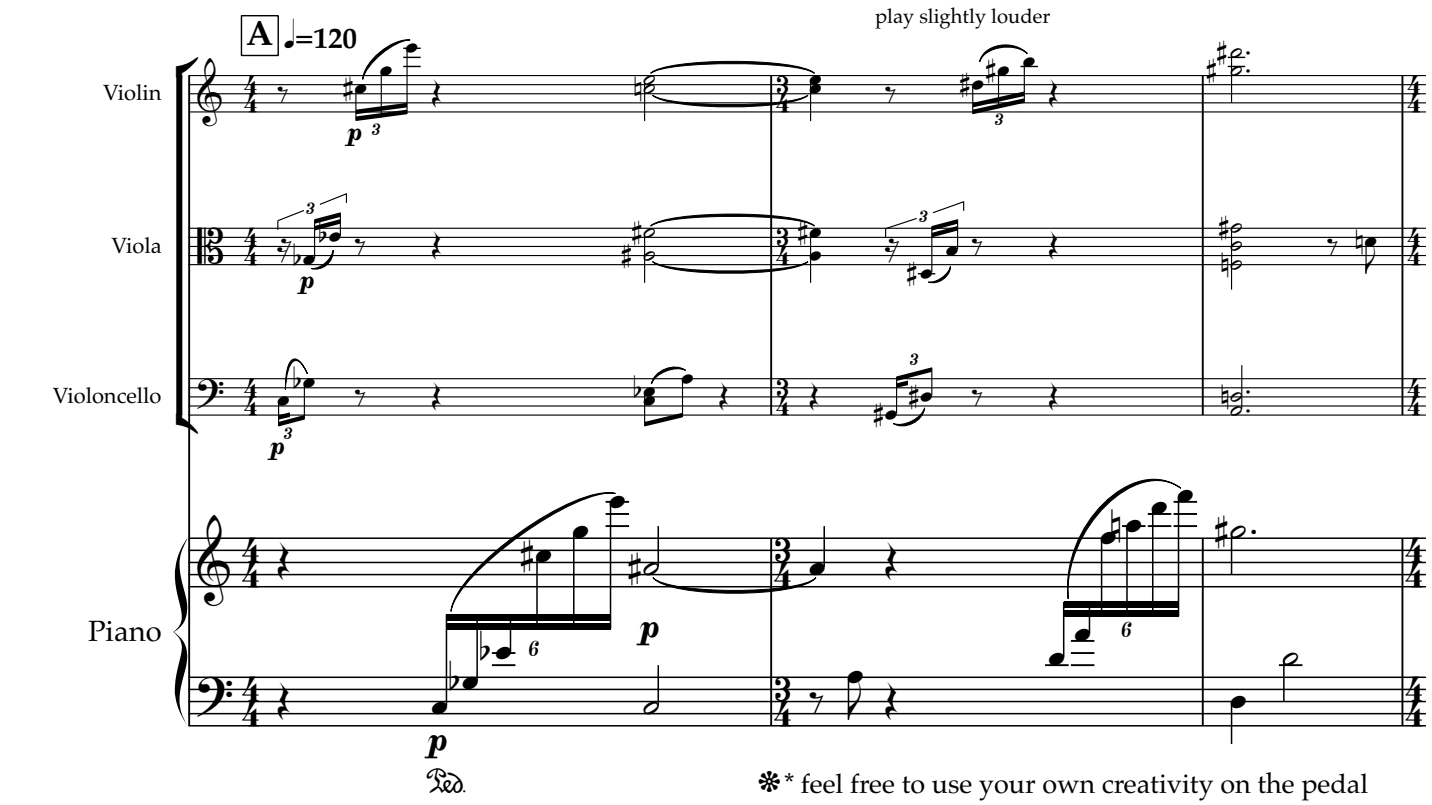
Duration: 6:43
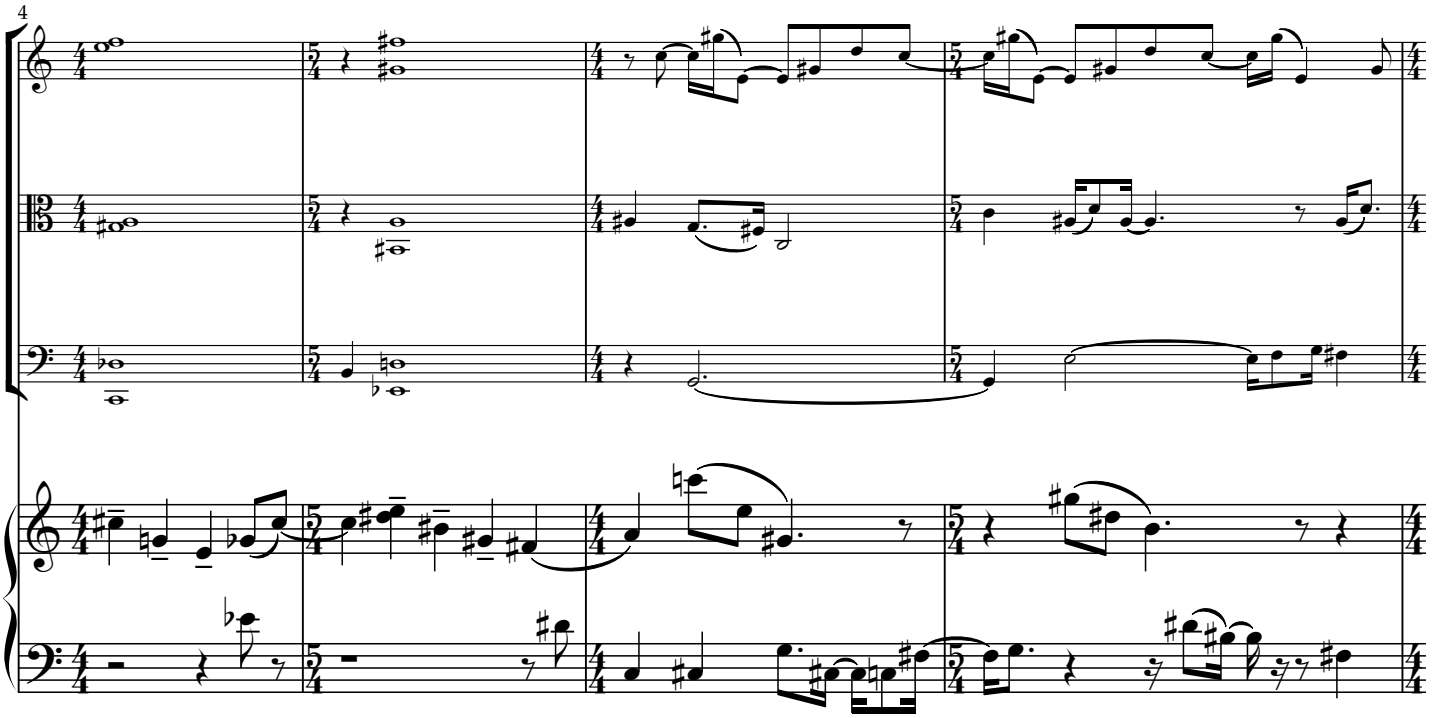
# War

for Piano Quartet

## I. Conflict
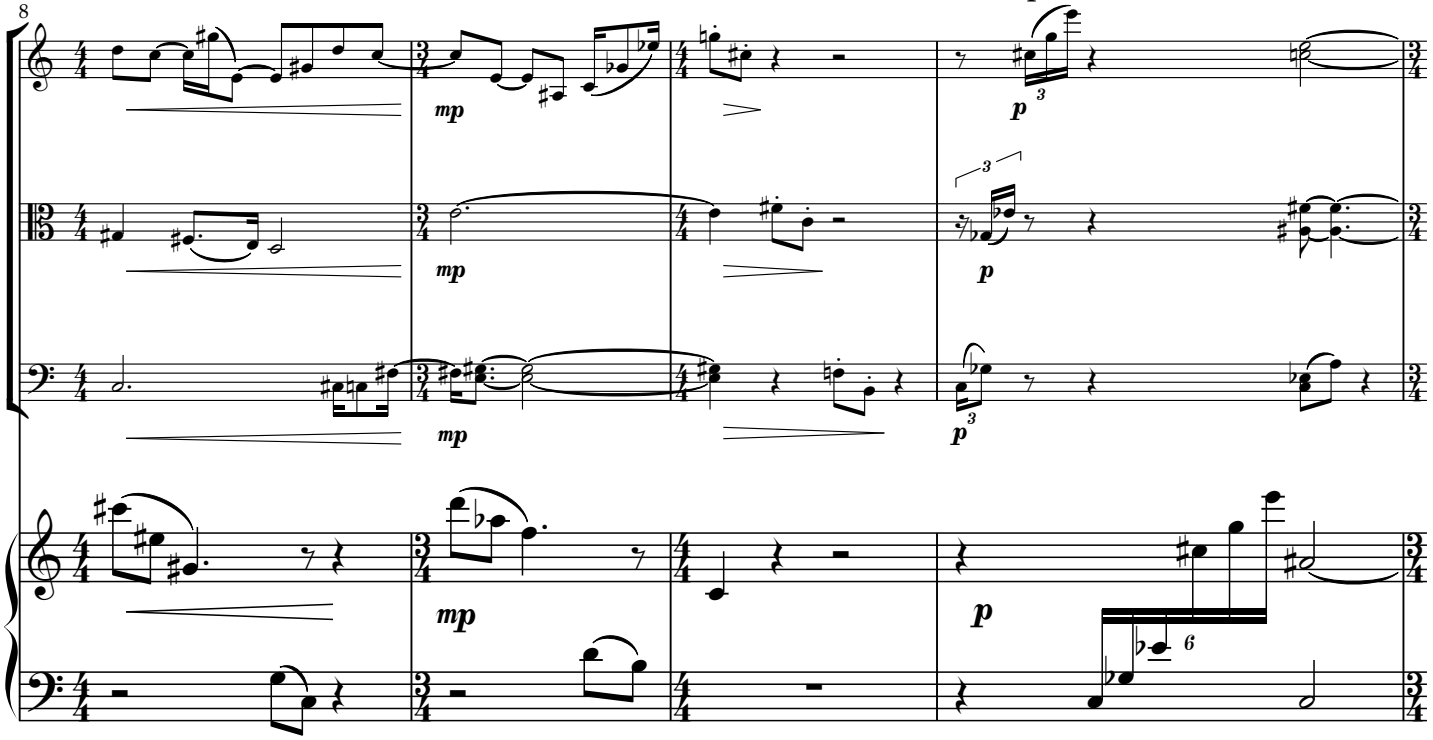
**Adrian Zhang**
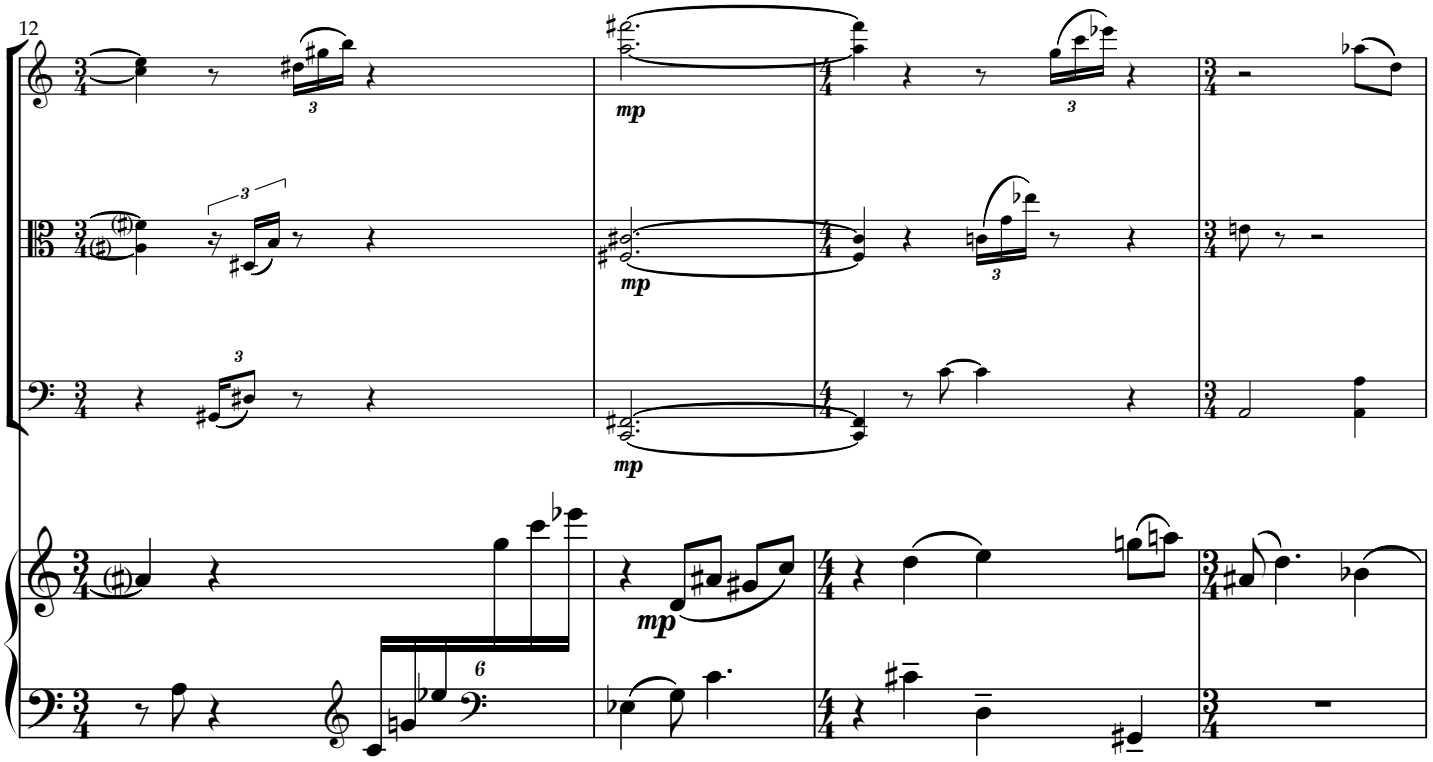





8
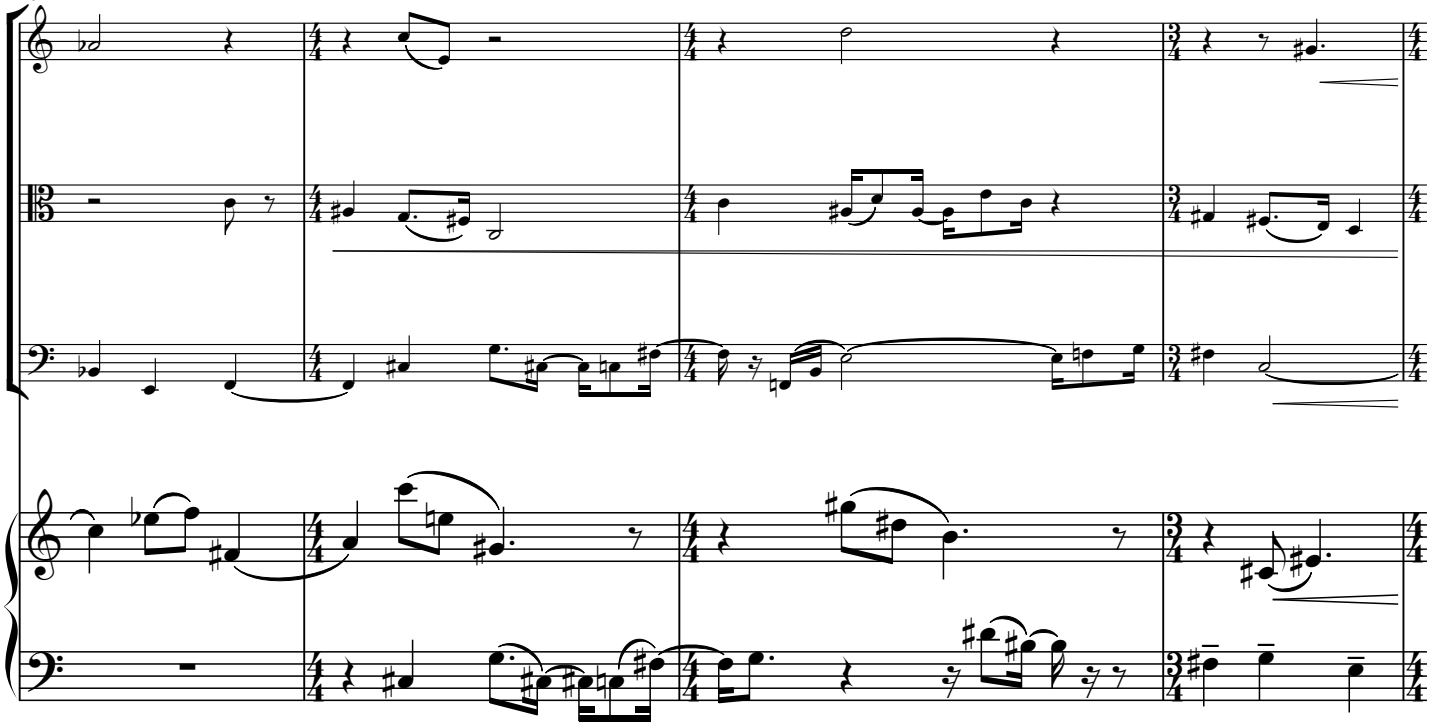
rit. - - - - - A tempo
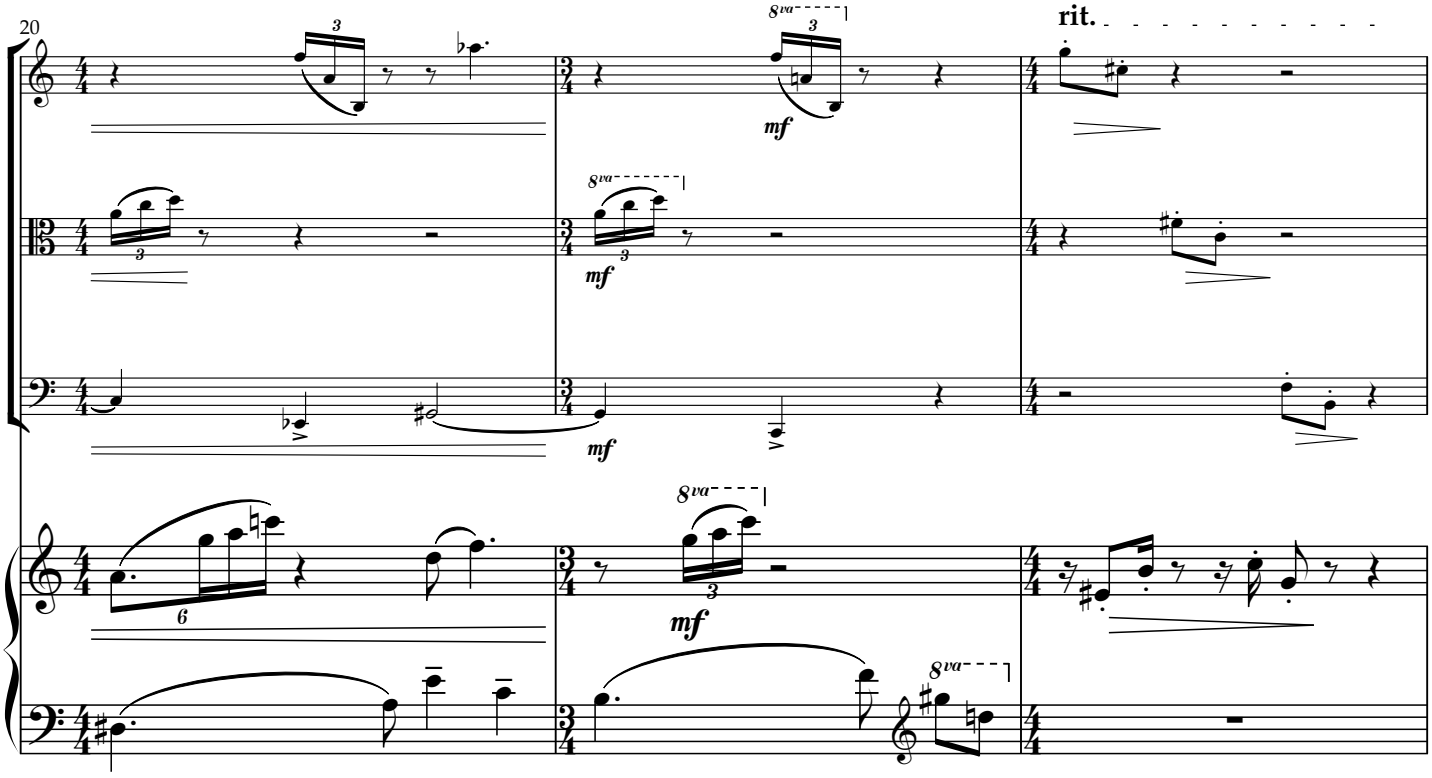



12
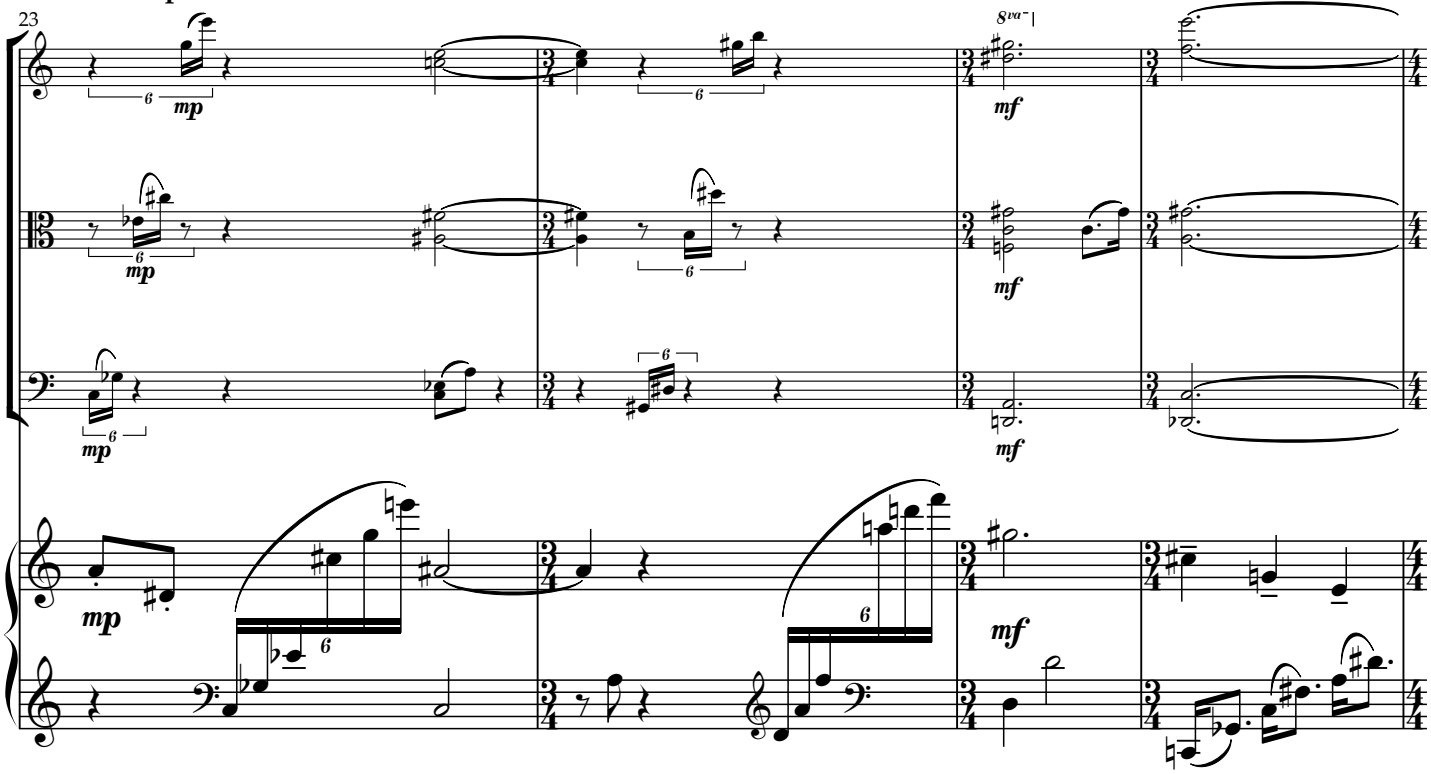


16
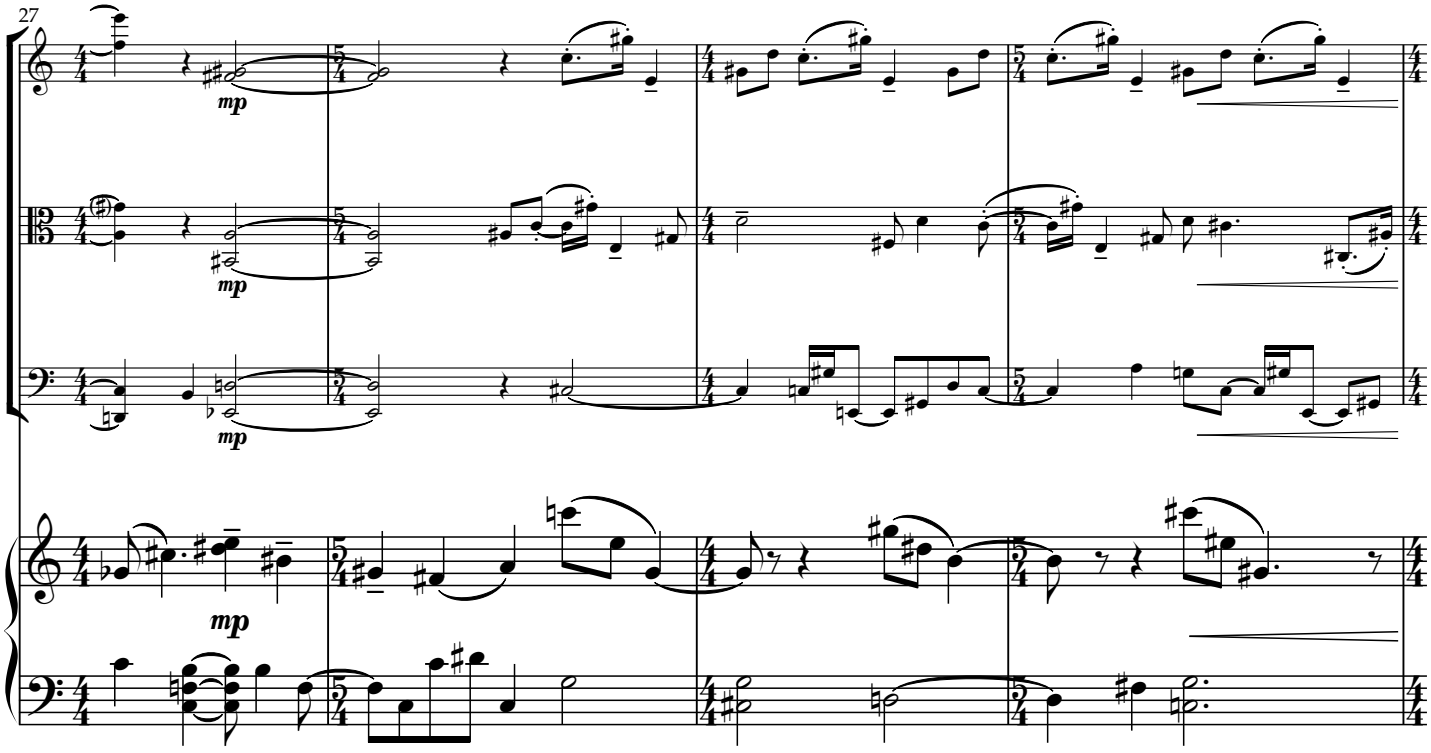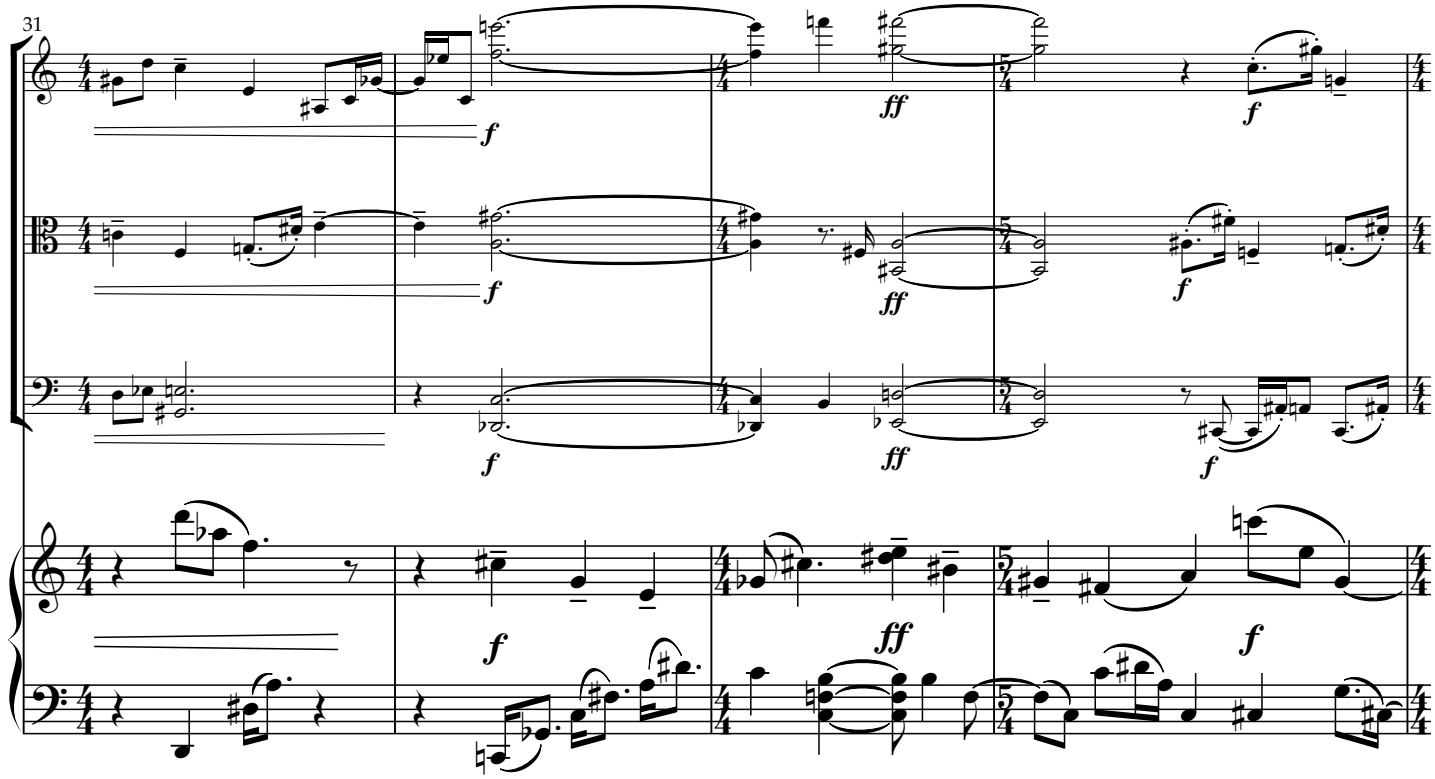


20
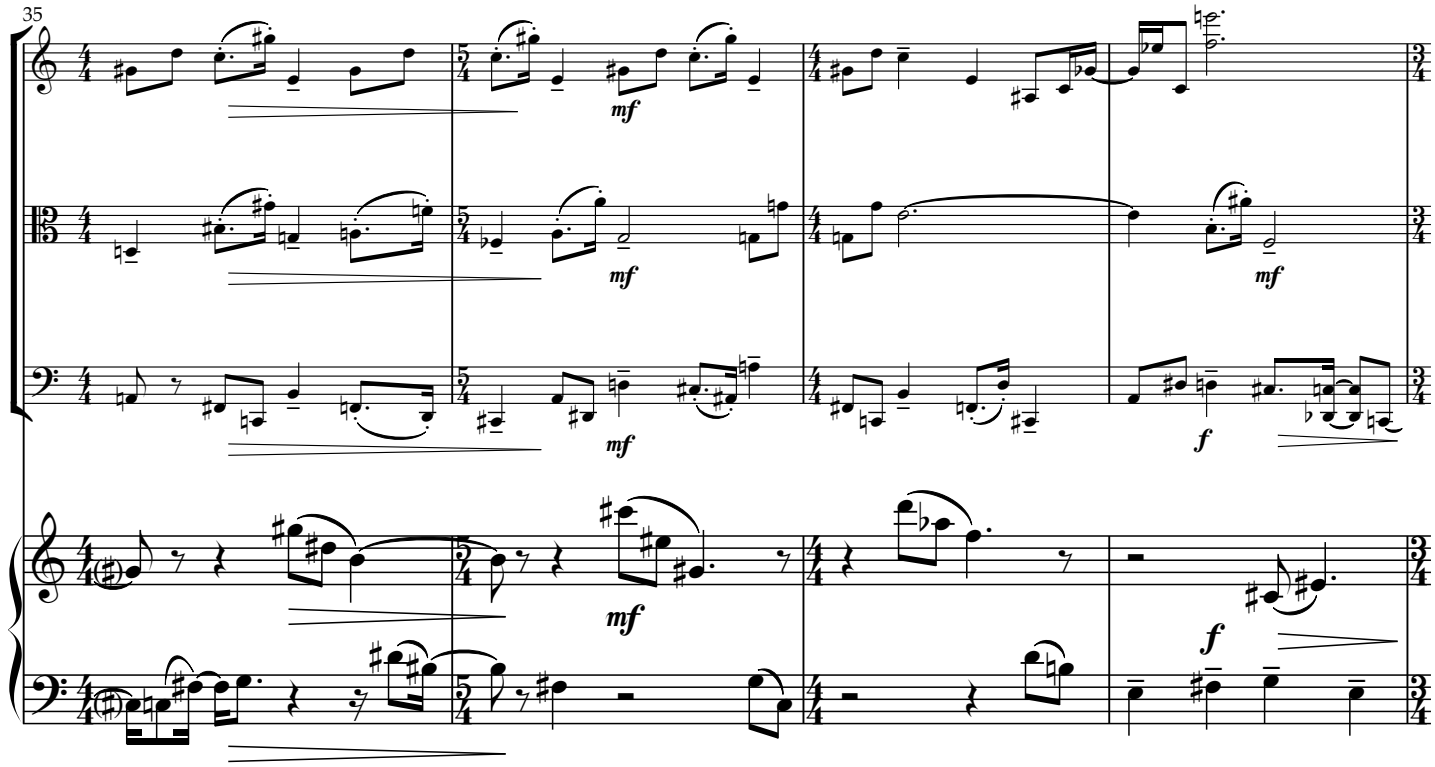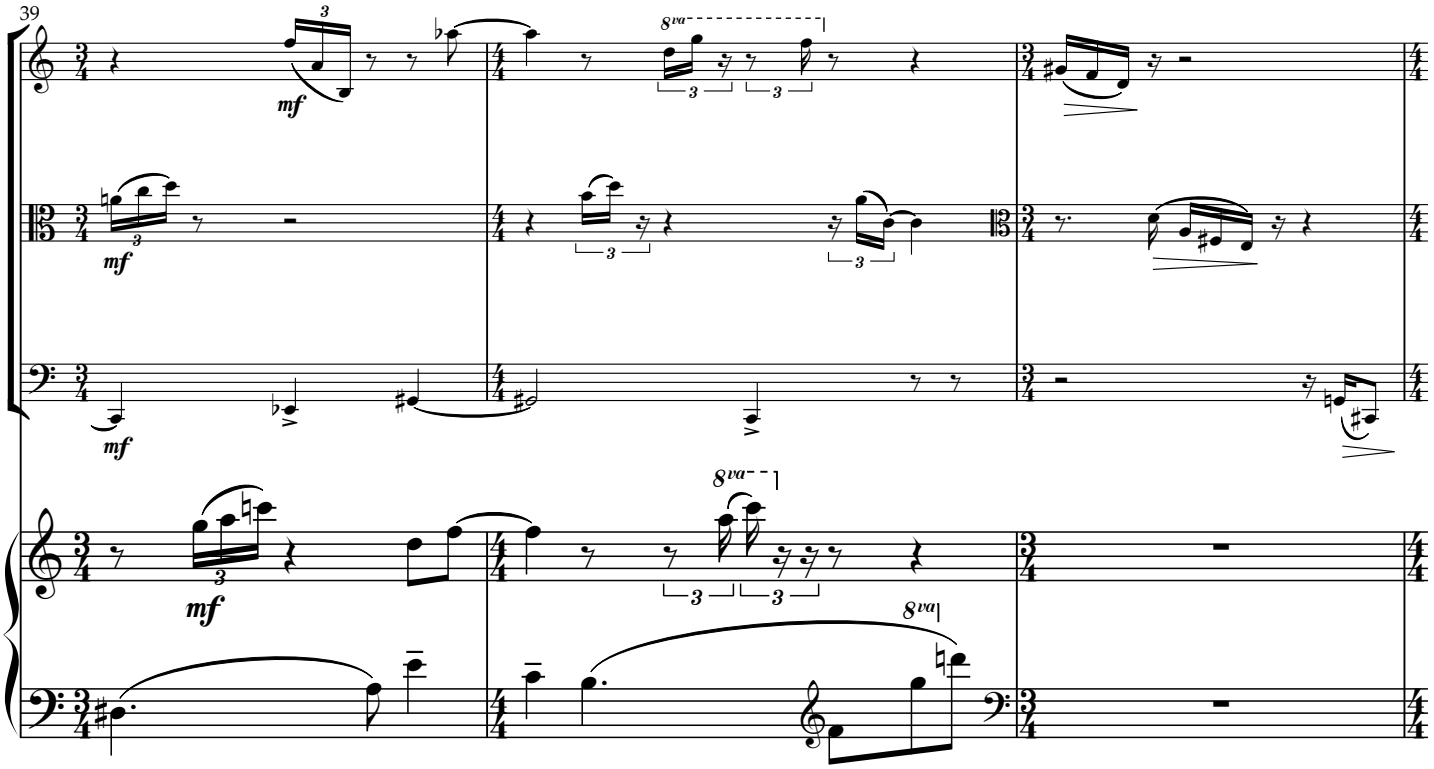


**A tempo**
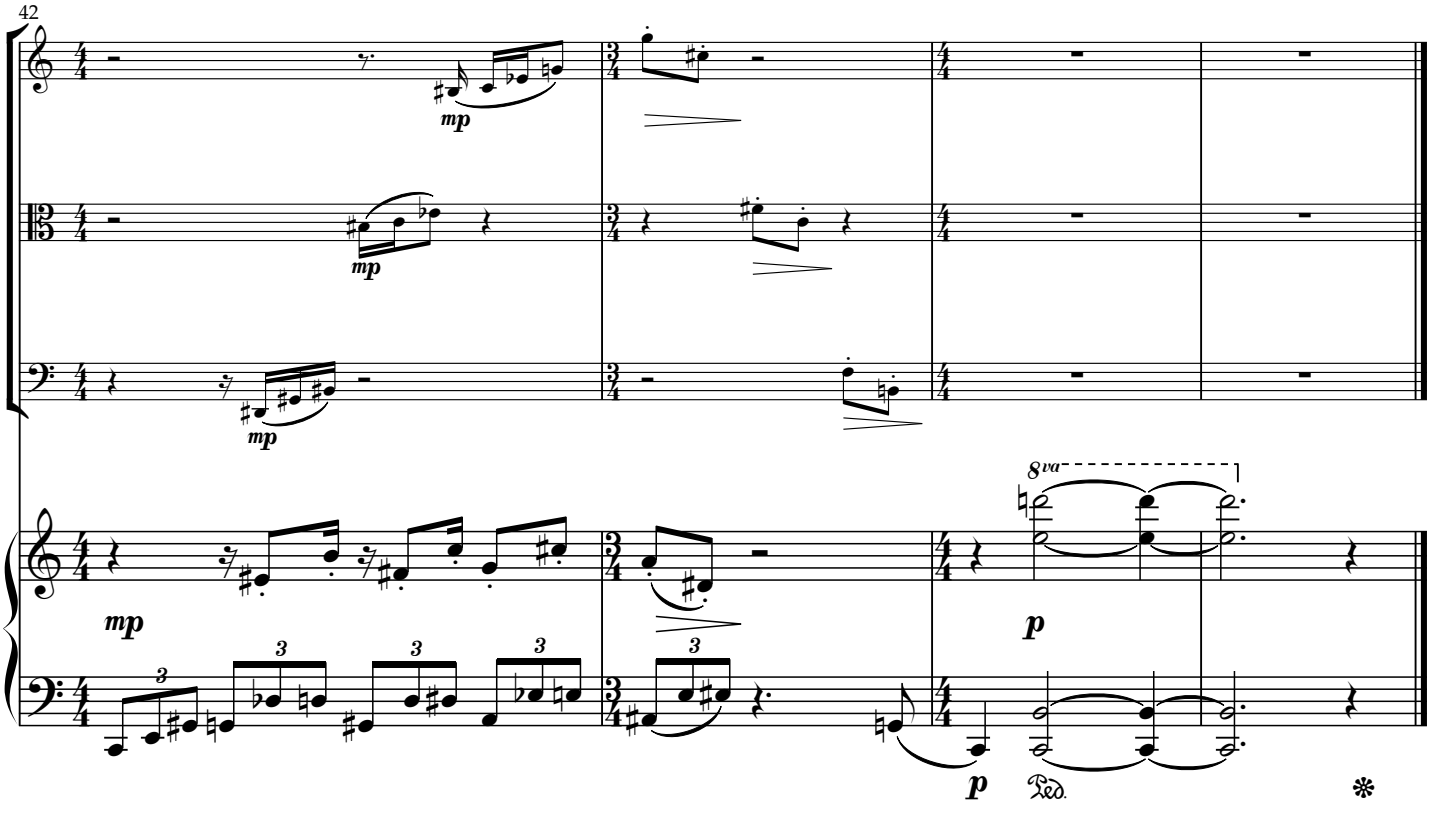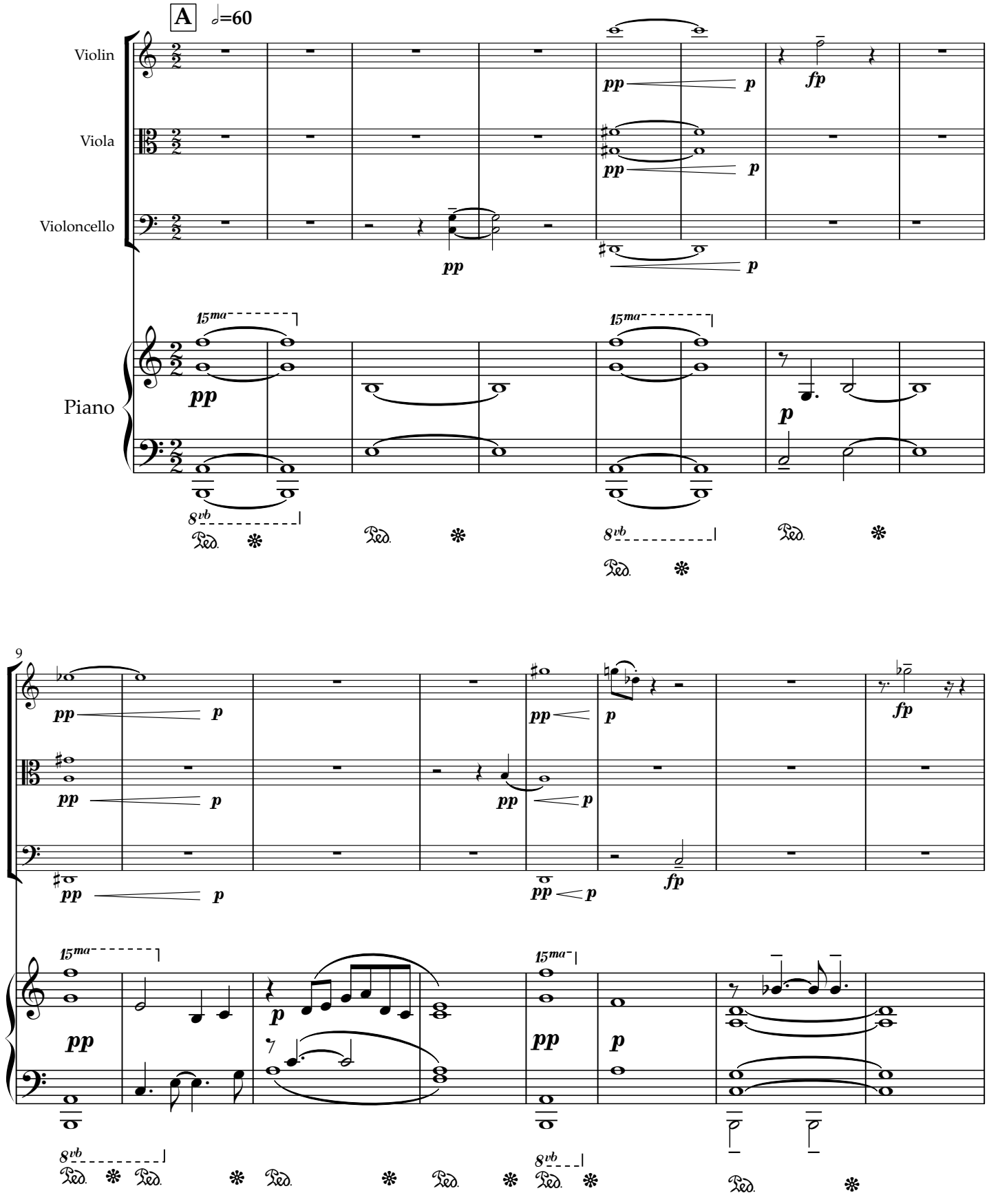






31
f
ff
f
f
ff
f
f
ff
f

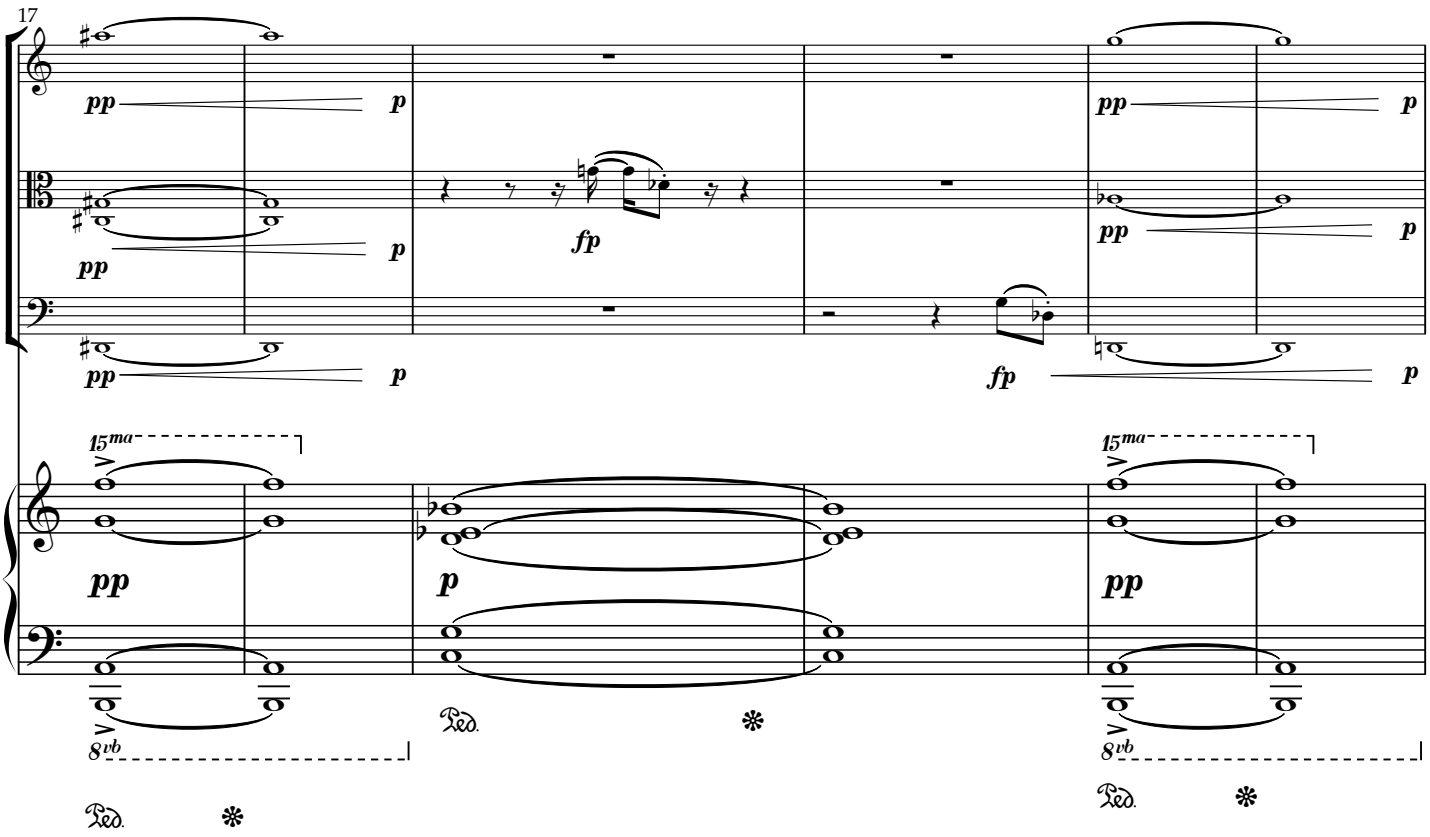

35
mf
mf
mf
f
mf
f
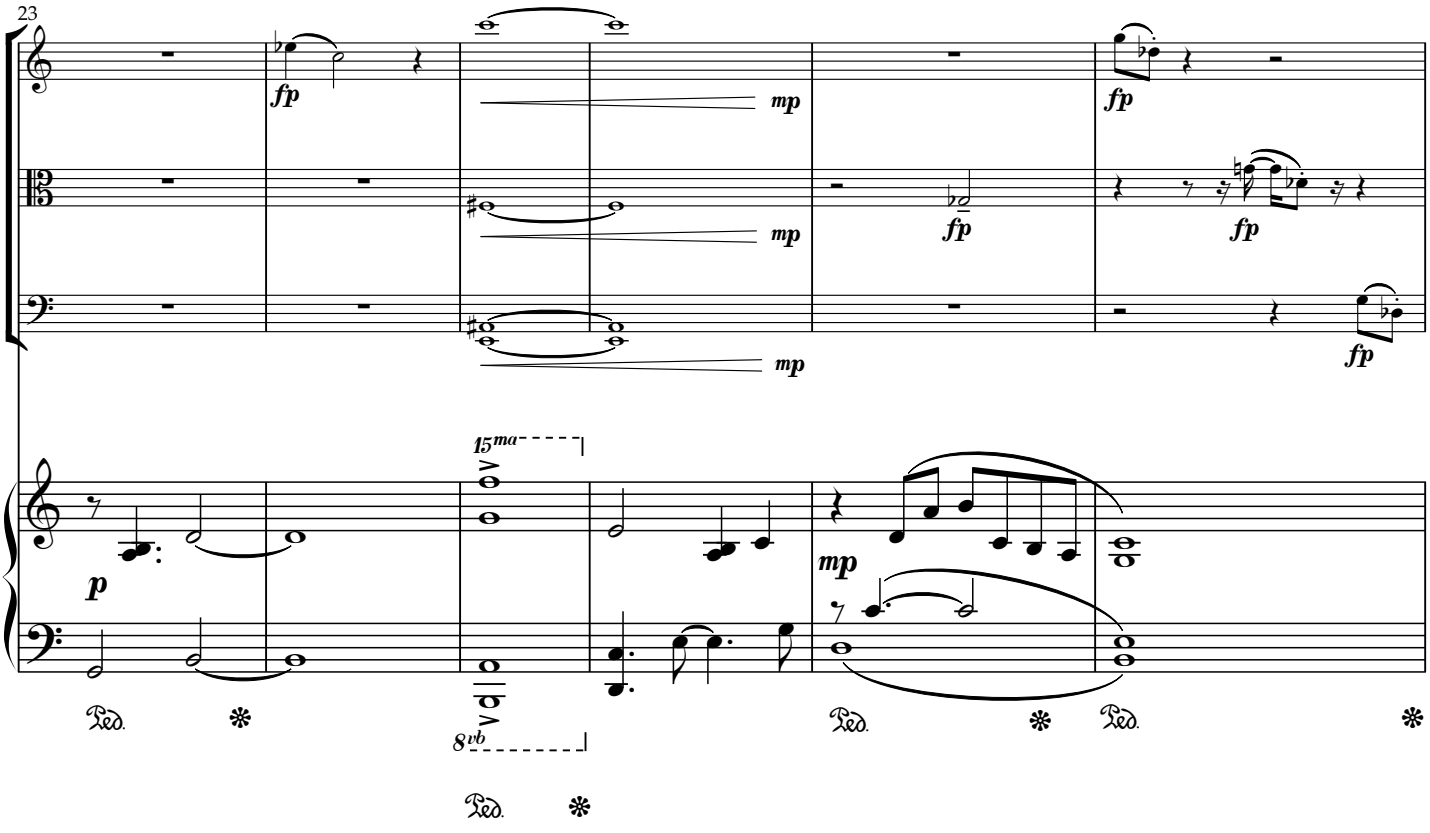

39
mf
8va
mf
mf
8va
8va

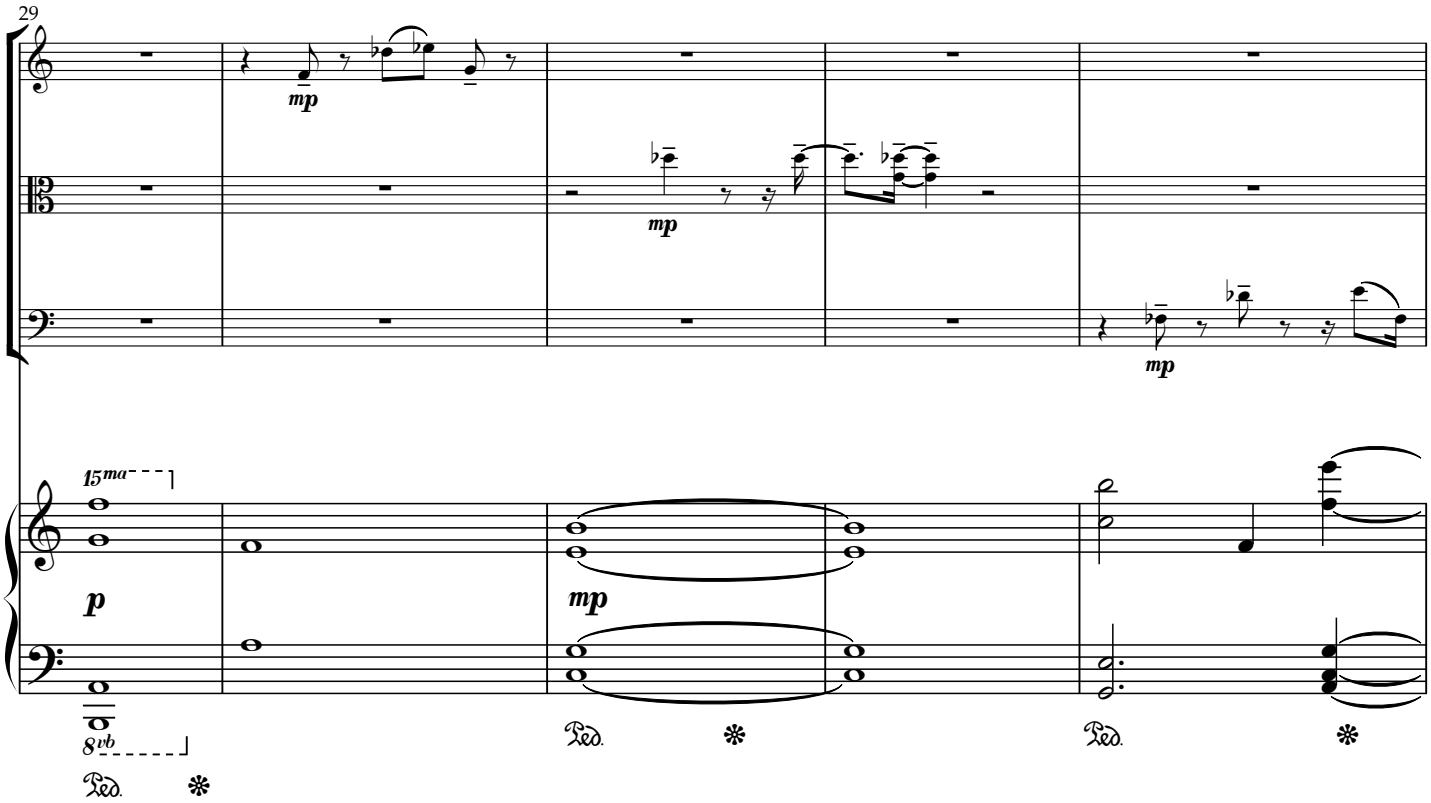

42
mp
mp
mp
mp
8va
p
p
Ped.

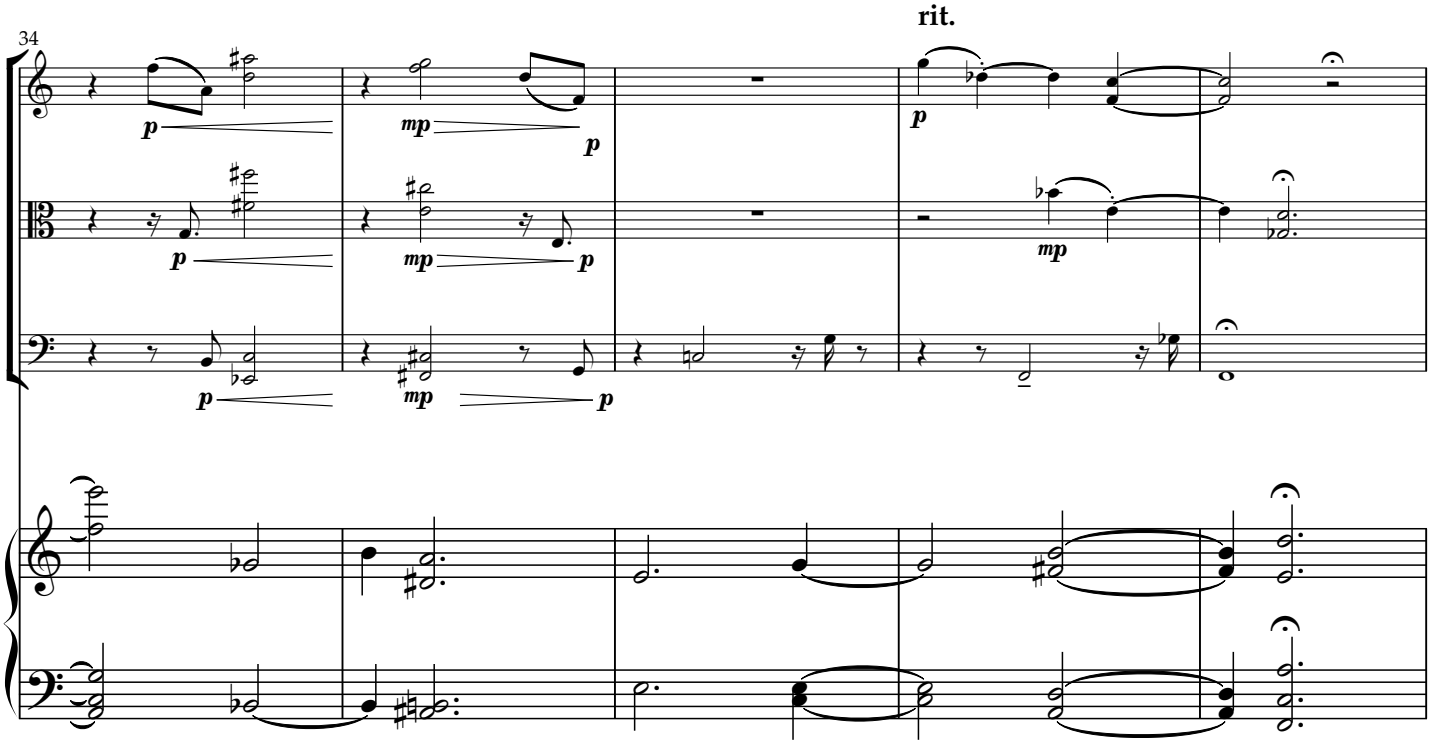
# II. Desolation
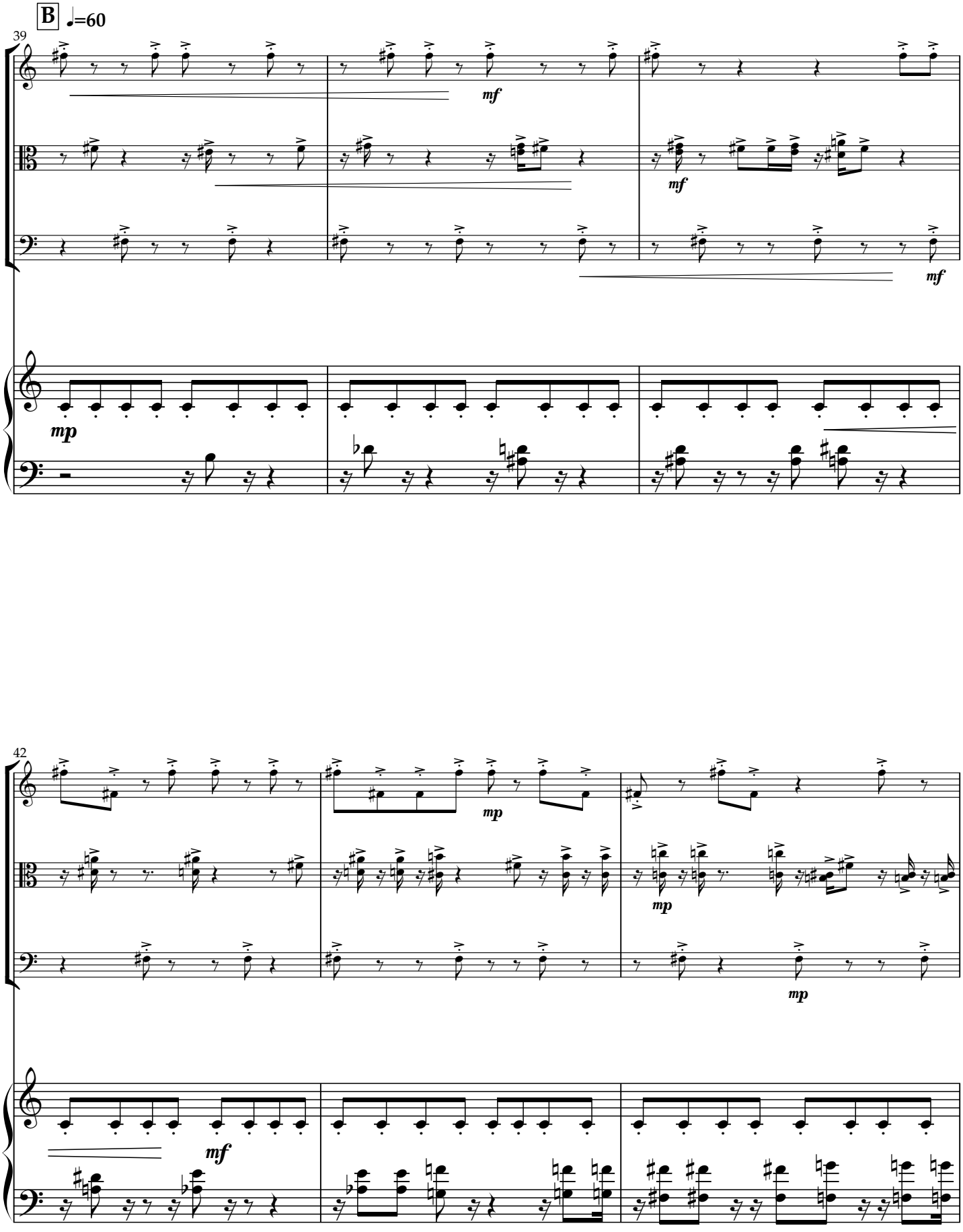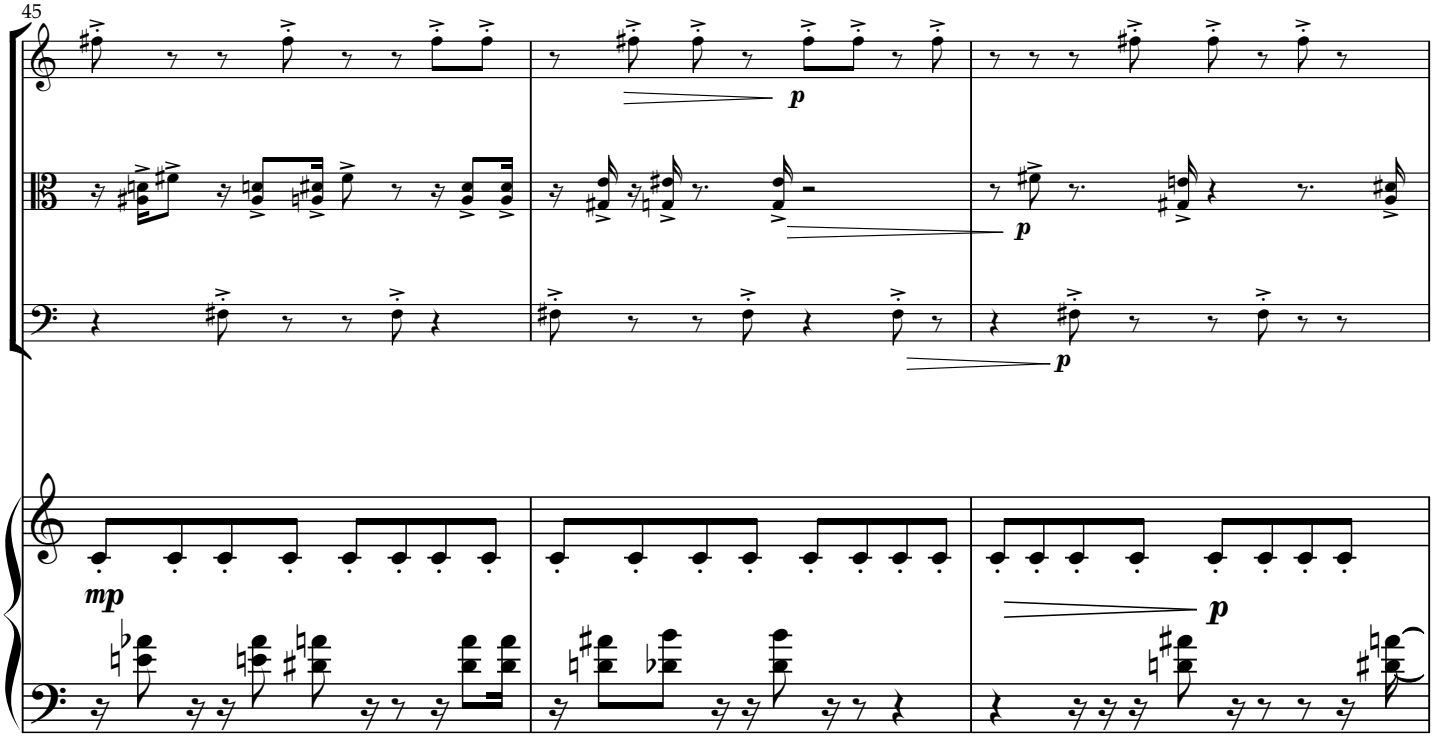



17
pp
p
fp
15ma
8vb
Ped.
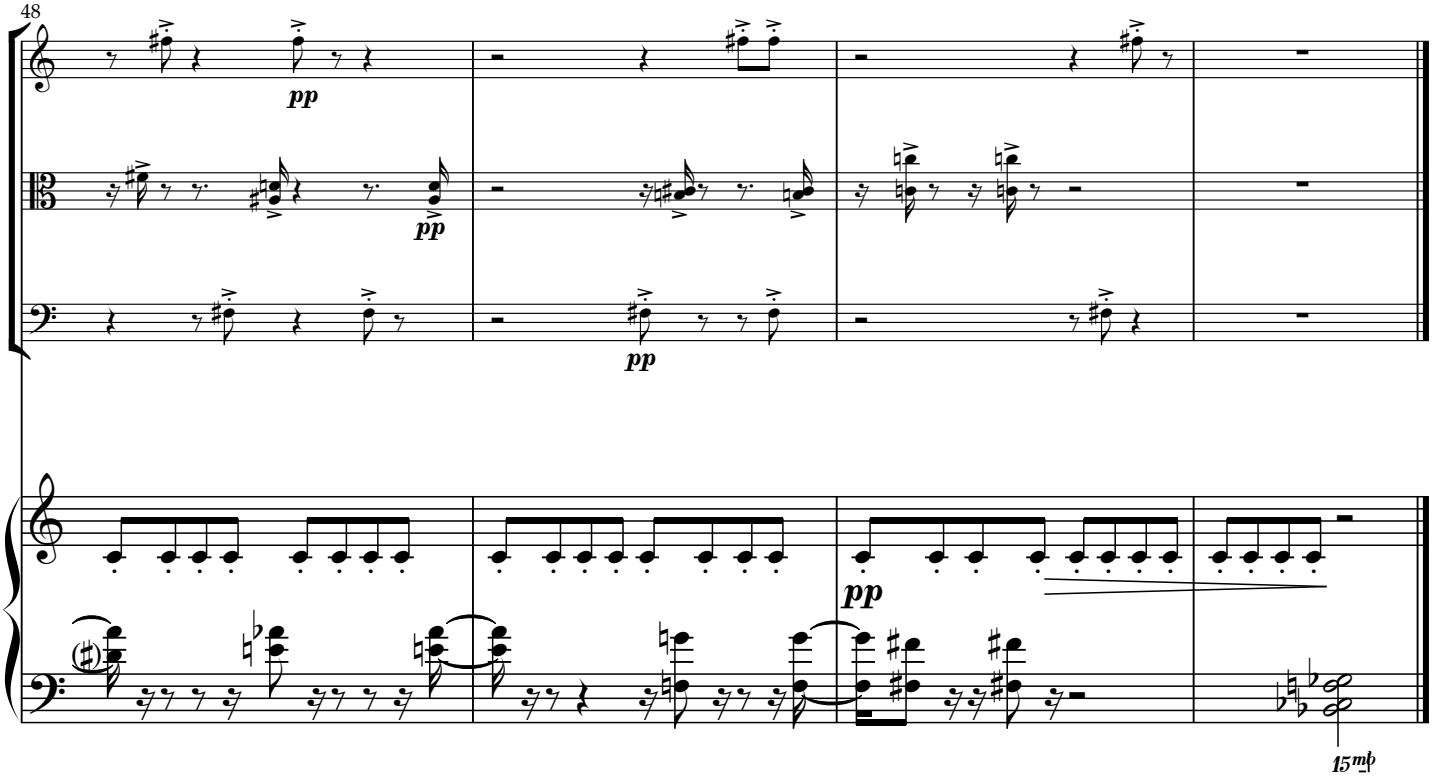

23
fp
mp
p
15ma
8vb
Ped.


29
mp
mp
mp
15ma
p
mp
8vb
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
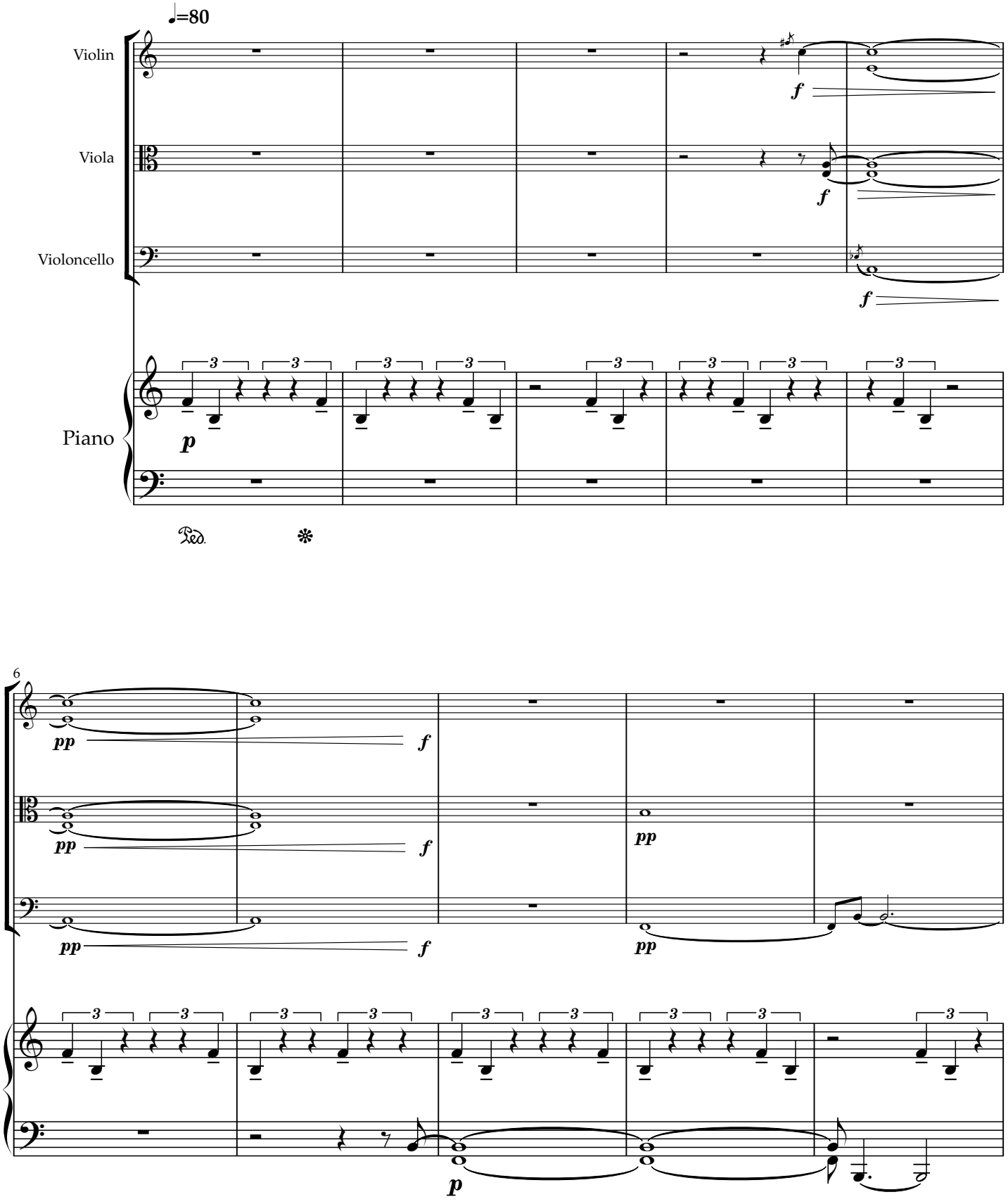

34
rit.
p
mp
p
p
mp
p
p
mp
p
mp
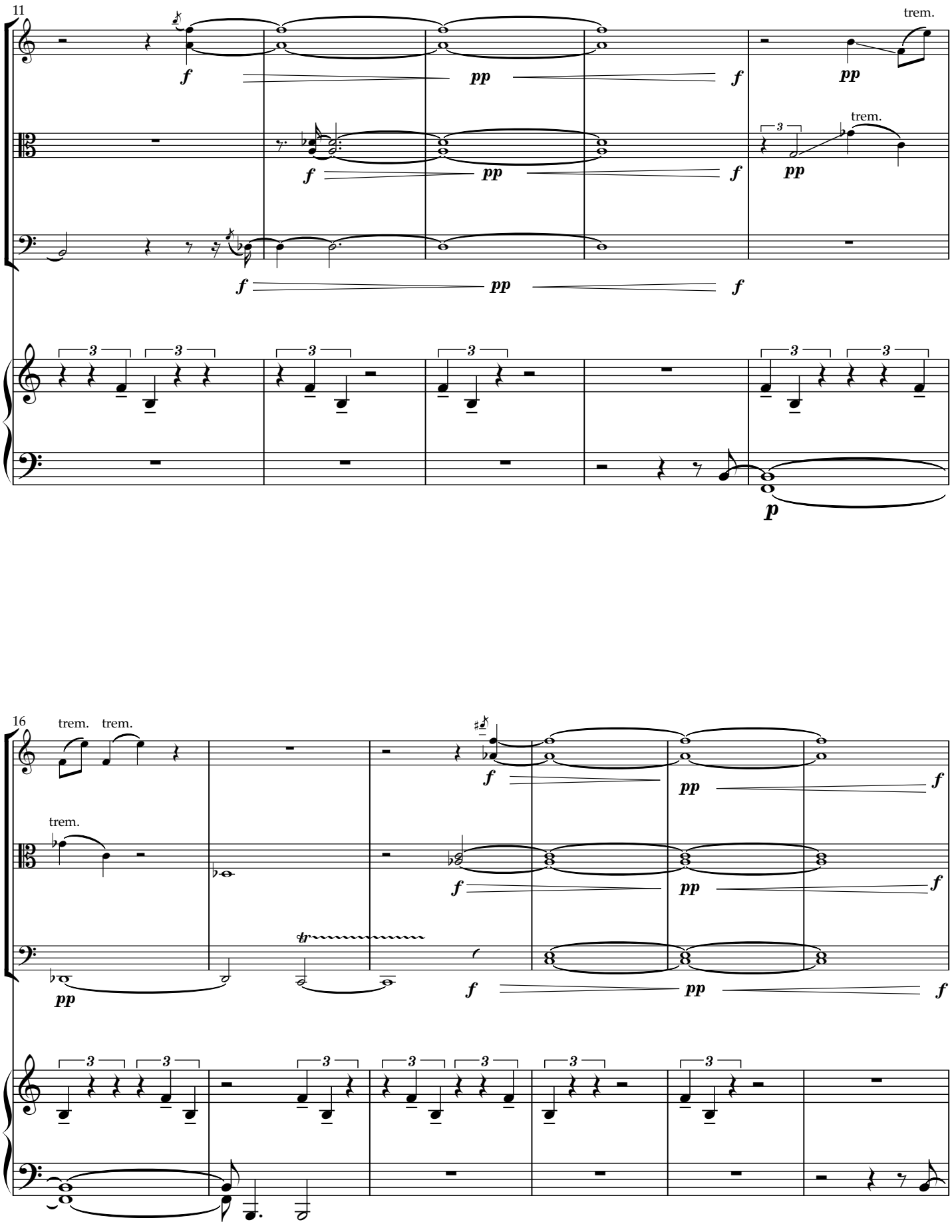

B
♩=60
39
mf
mf
mf
mp
42
mp
mp
mp
mf

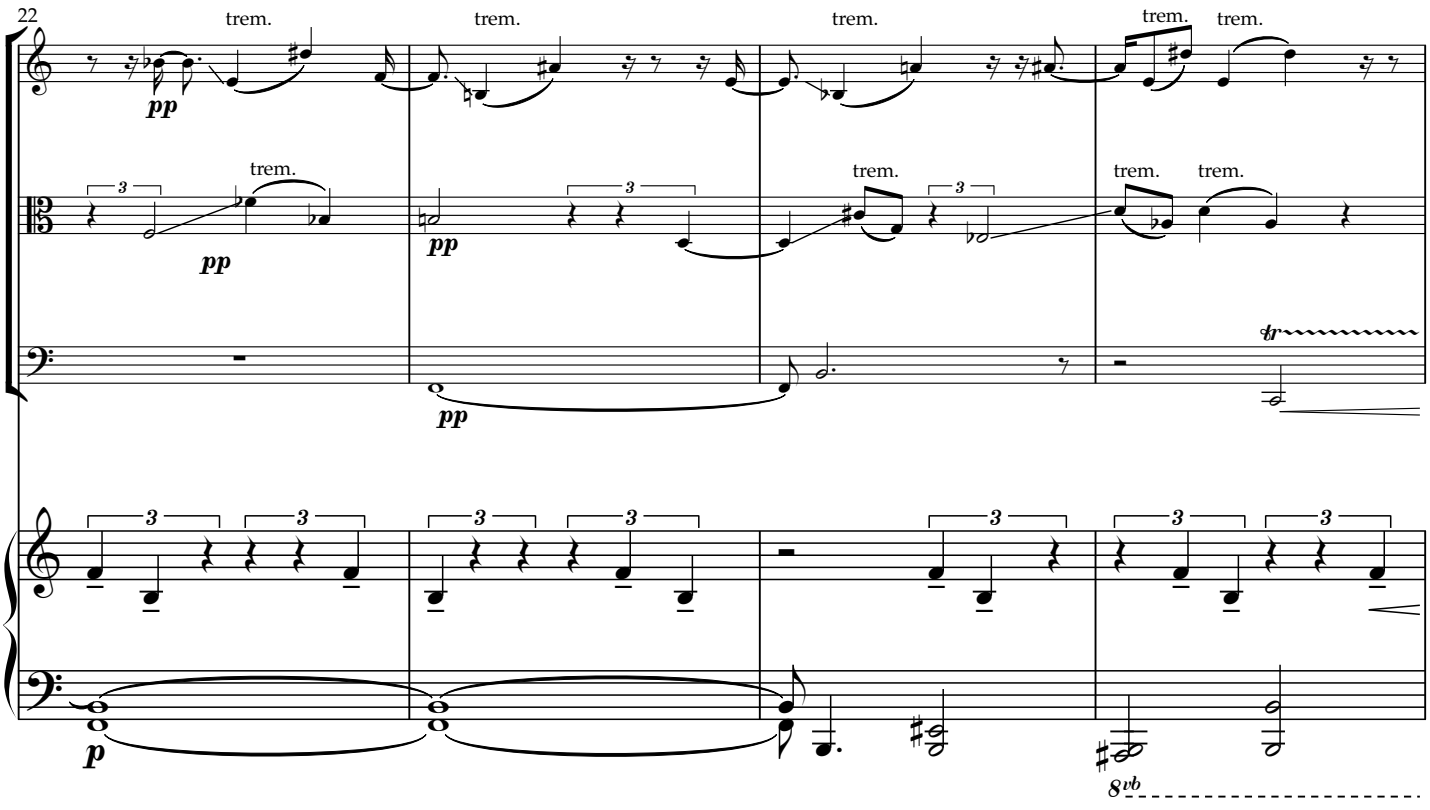

45
p
p
p
mp
p

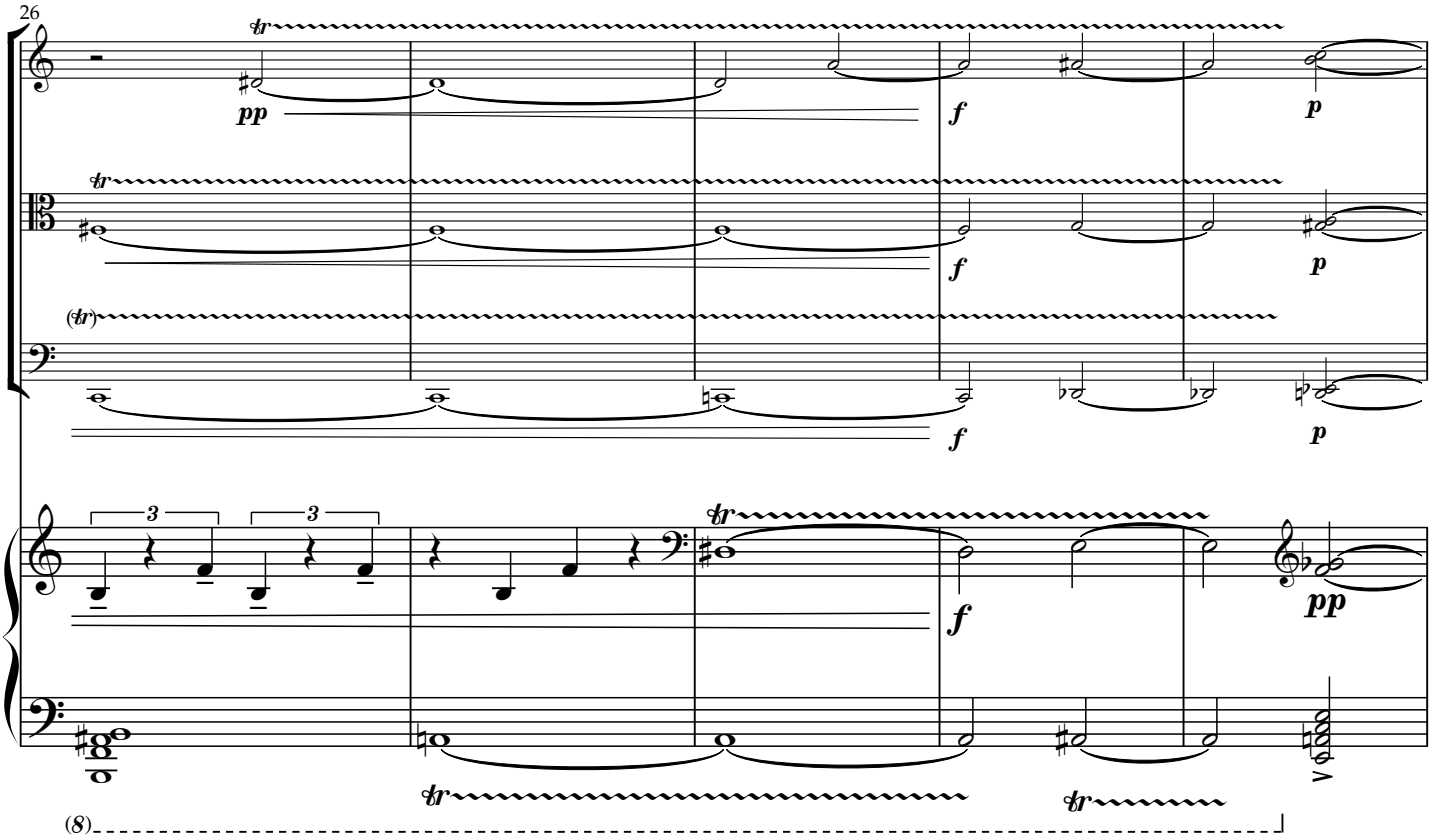

48
pp
pp
pp
pp
15mb

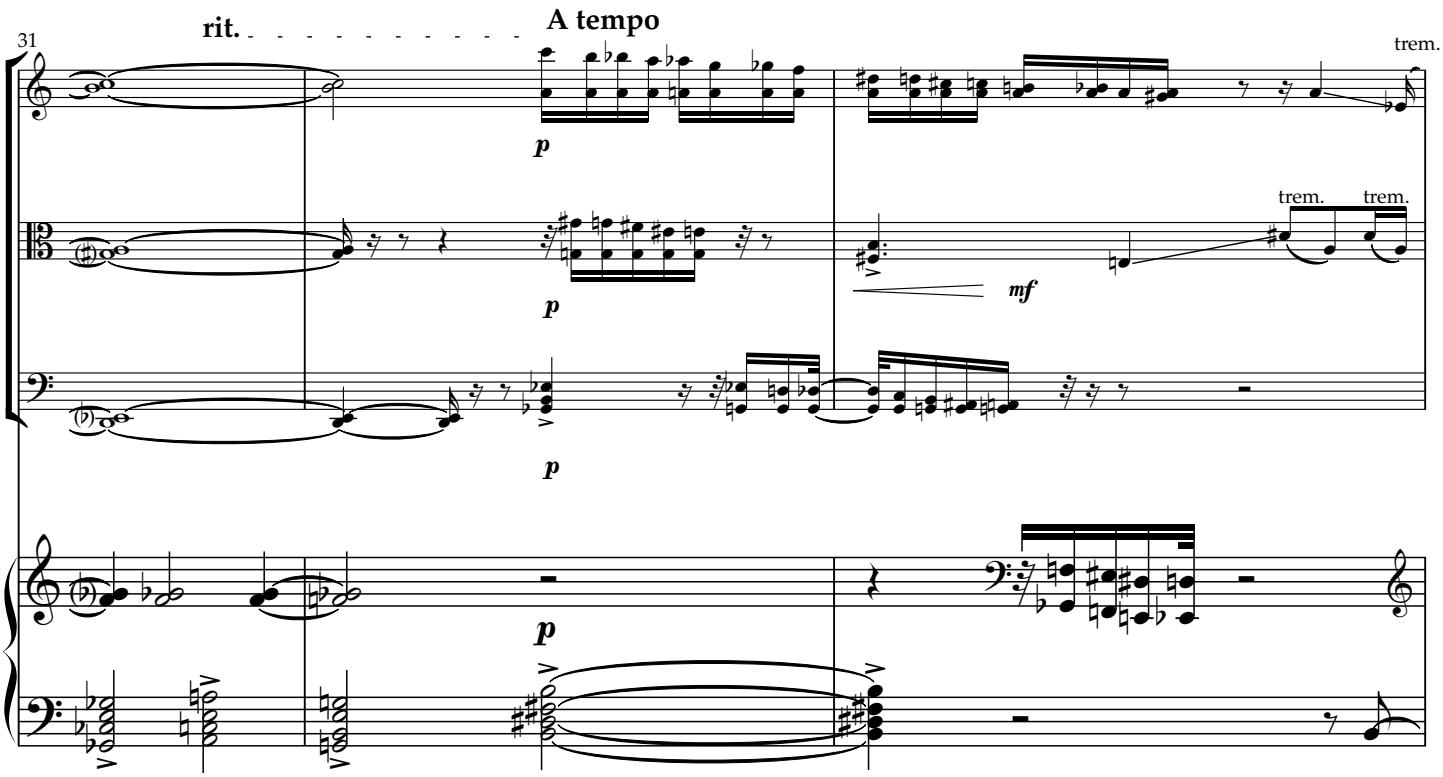
# III. Death

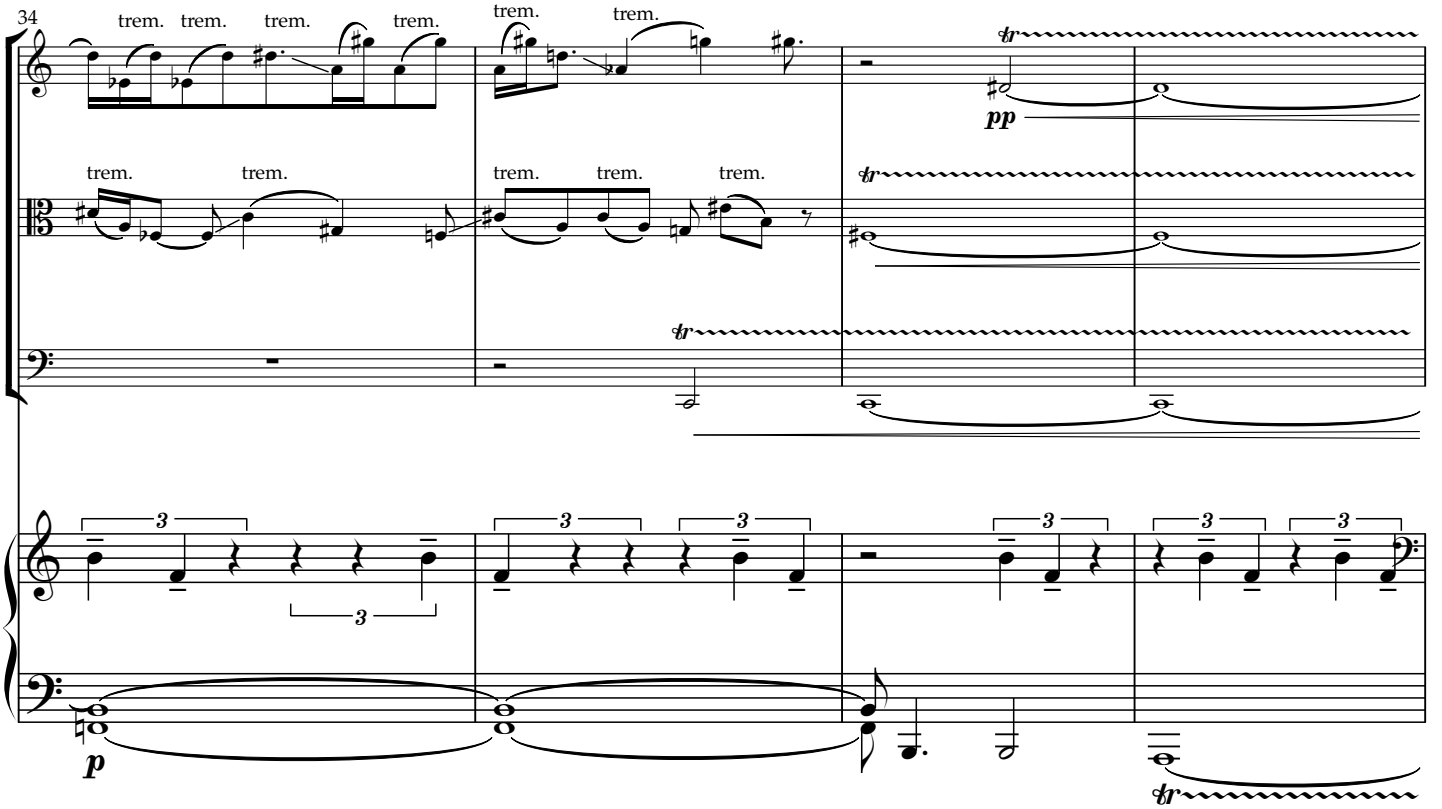


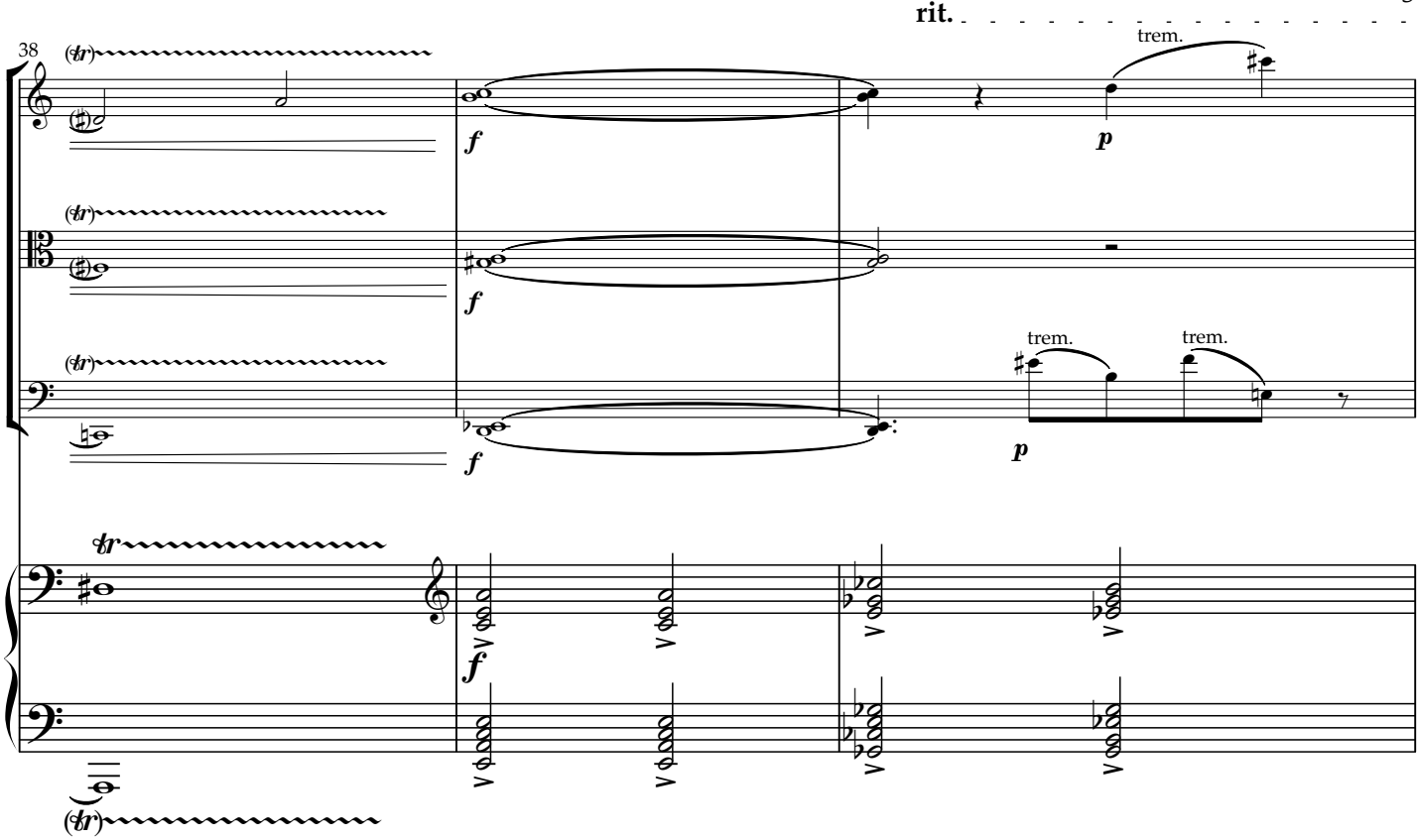

11
trem.
trem.
trem.
16
trem. trem.
trem.
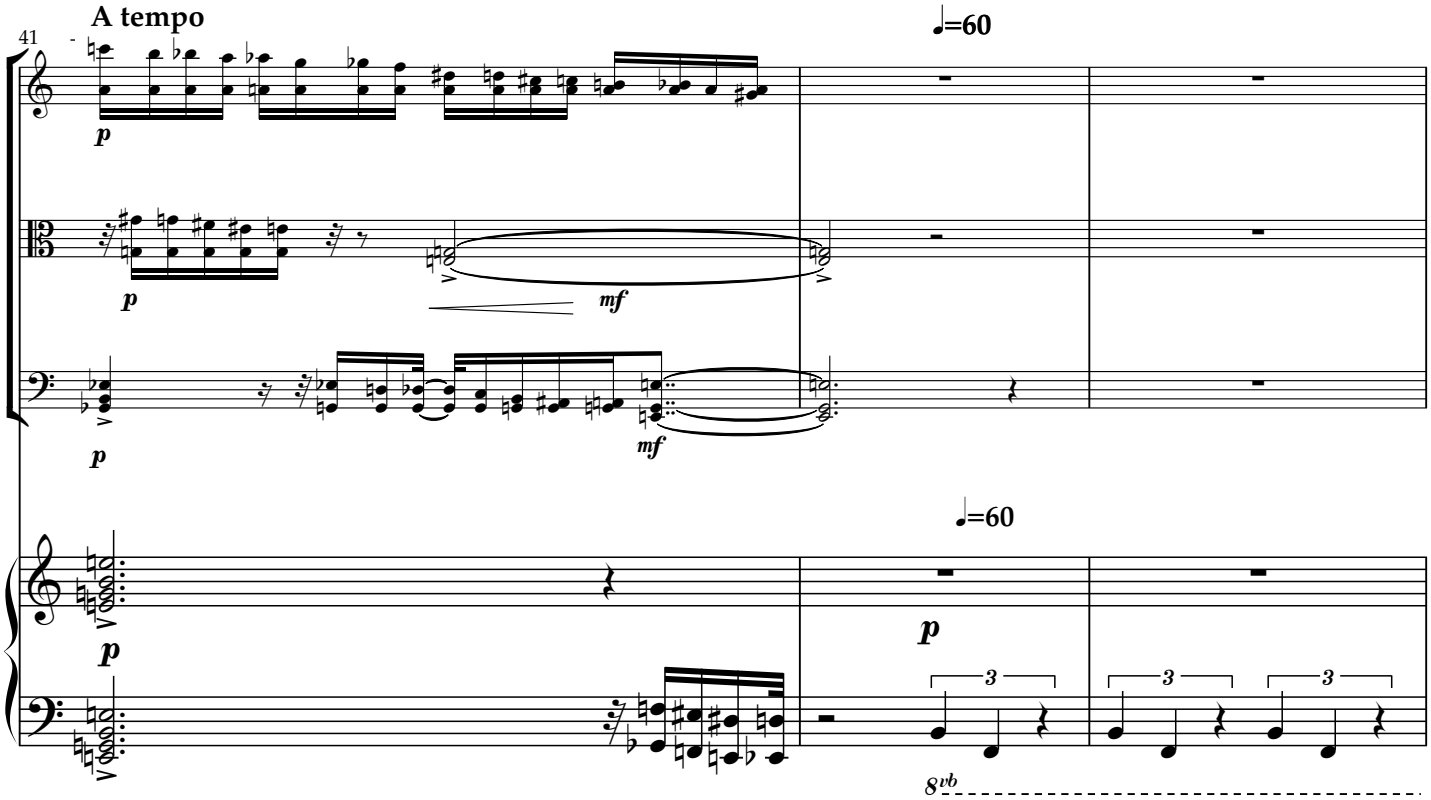

22
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
pp
pp
pp
pp
tr
p
8vb

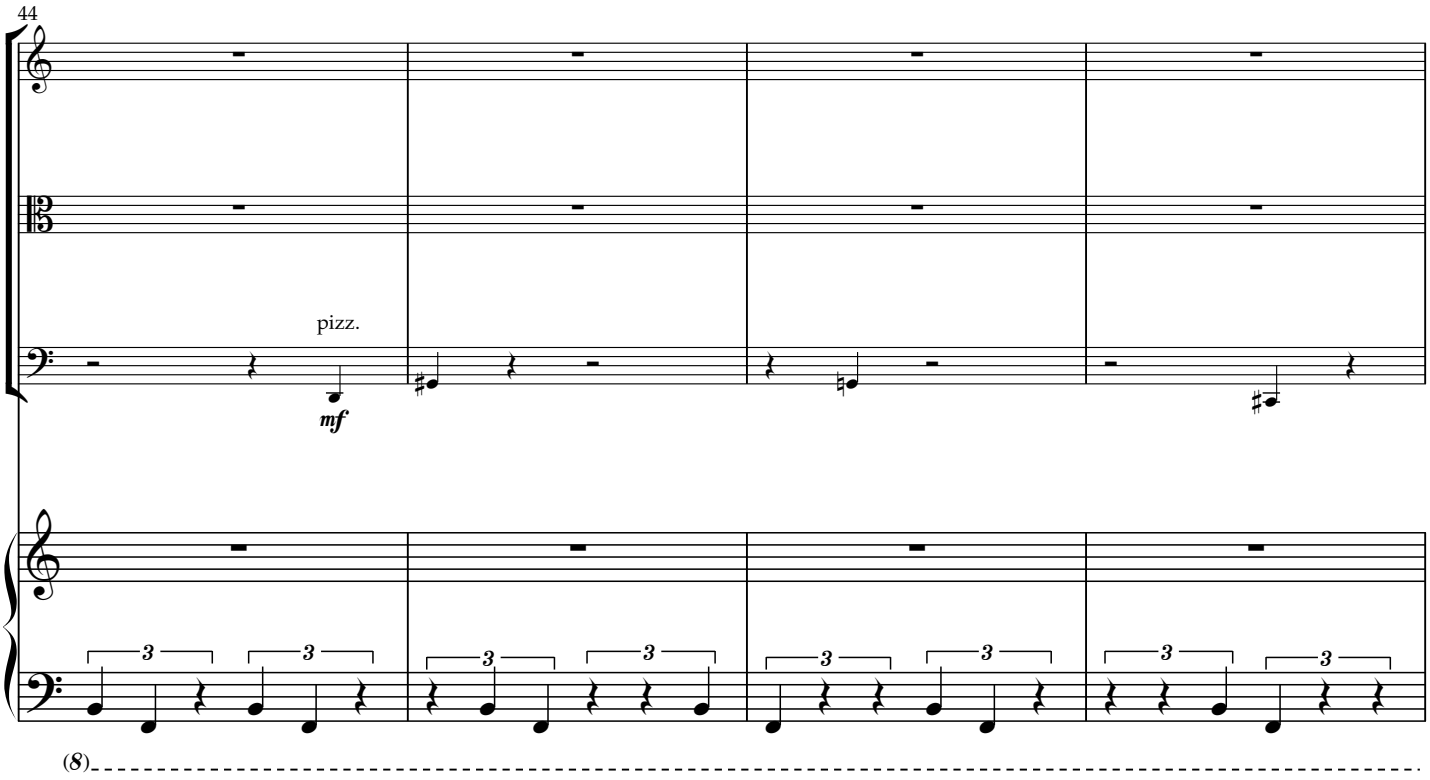

26
tr
pp
f
p
tr
f
p
(tr)
f
p
tr
f
pp
tr
tr
(8)

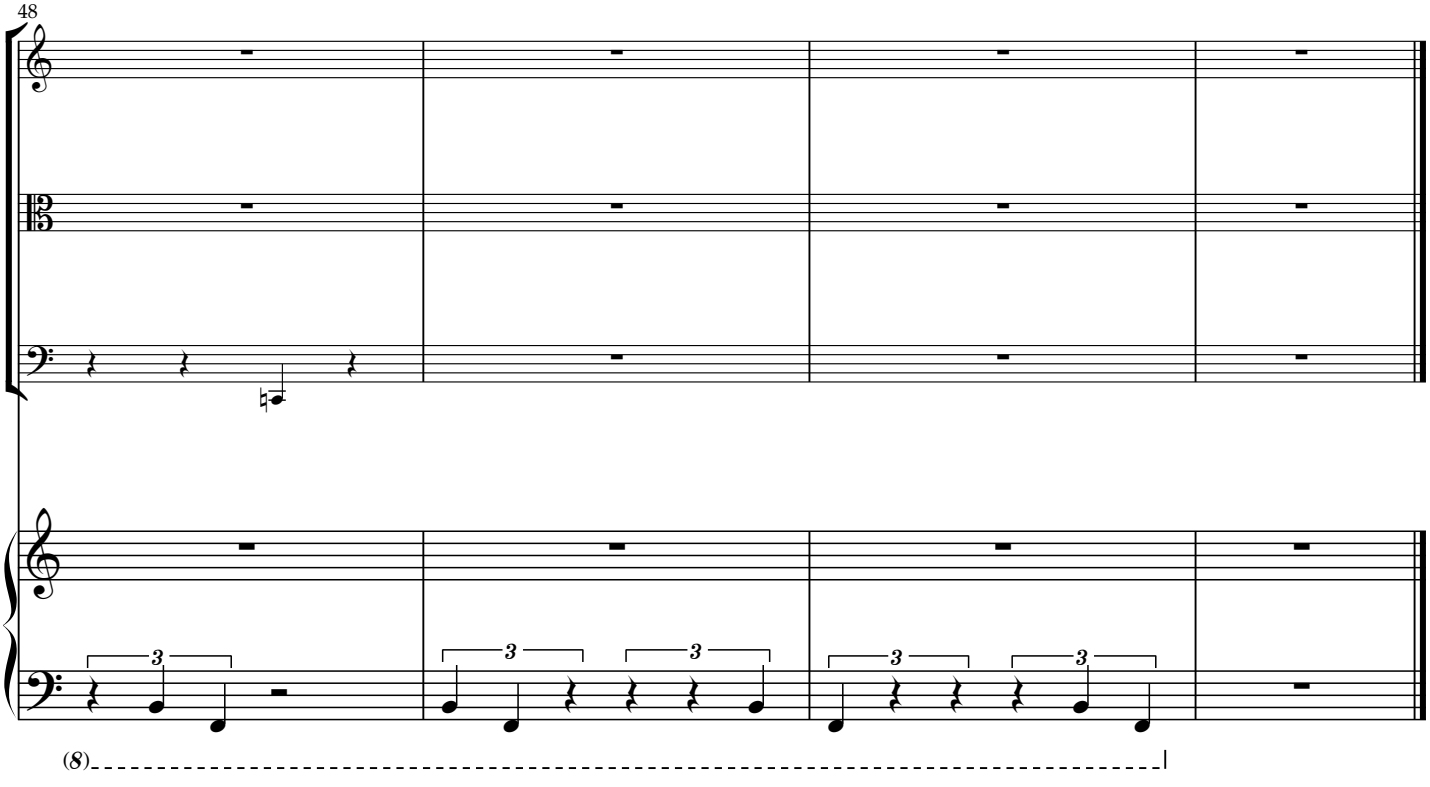

31
rit.
A tempo
trem.
trem.
trem.
p
p
p
p
mf


34
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
trem.
tr
pp
tr
tr
3
3
3
3
3
3
3
p
tr


rit.
38
(tr)
f
trem.
p
trem.
trem.


A tempo
41
p
mf
♩=60
8vb


44
pizz.
mf
3
(8)


48
3
(8)